

# Charles Taragin

PRINCIPAL ECONOMIST

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## CITIZENSHIP

### United States

## EXPERIENCE

### Federal Reserve Board

Washington DC

PRINCIPAL ECONOMIST

September 2022 - present

- Lead the economic analysis of bank mergers and divestitures, including the high-profile Capital One / Discover merger (joint Board and DOJ investigation).
- Architect spatial competition and distance-based algorithms to define retail banking markets and evaluate antitrust risk.

### Federal Trade Commission

Washington DC

ECONOMIST

June 2019 - September 2022

- Collaborated with attorneys to model and quantify competitive effects in merger investigations, including vertical integration in the NVIDIA / ARM semiconductor merger (FTC challenge).
- Investigated consumer harm from deceptive marketing practices, analyzing hidden lease terms and negative product review suppression.

### Antitrust Division, U.S. Department of Justice

Washington DC

ECONOMIST

September 2007 - May 2019

- Served as the lead or key economist on major merger investigations and litigations, including Anthem / Cigna (health insurance), American Airlines / US Airways (airlines), National CineMedia / Screenvision (cinema advertising), Twin America ('hop-on, hop-off' tour buses), Standard Parking / Central Parking (parking facilities), and radio station advertising mergers.
- Modeled market-wide pricing and welfare impacts of trade tariffs and import quotas proposed by the administration.
- Authored core code and mathematical frameworks (in R and Stata) for horizontal merger, tariff, and quota simulations used standardly in Antitrust Division investigations.
- Designed and coded interactive web interfaces for merger and tariff simulation tools.
- Designed and maintained massive databases (exceeding 10 TB) to support complex antitrust investigations and federal court litigation.

## EDUCATION

### Economics

University of Michigan

PHD

2007

### Economics

University of Michigan

MASTERS

2004

### Public Policy

University of Chicago

MASTERS

2000

### Economics

University of Chicago

BACHELORS

1999

## PUBLICATIONS

1. Taragin, C., & Taylhardat, M. (2025). A distance-based algorithm for defining antitrust markets. *Finance Research Letters*, 86, 108972. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.frl.2025.108972>
2. Benson, D., Bord, V., Garner, A., & Taragin, C. (2023). *Size and survival of entrants to retail banking*. Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System; FEDS Notes. <https://doi.org/10.17016/2380-7172.3345>
3. Panhans, M. T., & Taragin, C. (2023). Consequences of model choice in predicting horizontal merger effects. *International Journal of Industrial Organization*, 89, 102986. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijindorg.2023.102986>
4. Vita, M., Brand, K., Larson-Koester, M., Petek, N., Taragin, C., Violette, W., & Wood, D. H. (2022). Economics at the FTC: Estimating harm from deception and analyzing mergers. *Review of Industrial Organization*, 61(4), 405–438. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11151-022-09883-w>
5. Sheu, G., & Taragin, C. (2021). Simulating mergers in a vertical supply chain with bargaining. *The RAND Journal of Economics*, 52(3), 596–632. <https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.1111/1756-2171.12385>
6. Froeb, L. M., Mares, V., Tschantz, S., & Taragin, C. (2018). The simple algebra of surplus in private values open auctions: A nested logit merger model. *Economics Bulletin*, 38(4), 2304–2312. <https://ideas.repec.org/a/eb1/ecbull/eb-18-00431.html>

7. Froeb, L. M., Pittman, R. W., Taragin, C. S., Tschantz, S., & Werden, G. J. (2018). Economics at the Antitrust Division: 2017–2018. *Review of Industrial Organization*, 53(4), 637–651. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11151-018-9662-8>
8. Borzekowski, R., Thomadsen, R., & Taragin, C. (2009). Competition and price discrimination in the market for mailing lists. *QME*, 7(2), 147–179. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11129-009-9050-7>

## UNDER REVIEW

1. Taragin, C., Wallace, B., & Watkins, E. (2025). *Financial structure and mergers* (No. 2025-080; Finance and Economics Discussion Series). Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System. <https://doi.org/10.17016/FEDS.2025.080>
2. Hosken, D., Larson-Koester, M., & Taragin, C. (2025). *Labor and product market effects of mergers*.

## IN PROGRESS

1. Benson, D., Loudermilk, M., & Taragin, C. (2026). *Merger screening under uncertain conduct*.
2. Benson, D., Garner, A., Sheu, G., & Taragin, C. S. (2026). *Merger effects and efficiencies under uncertainty: Evidence from supreme court decisions on banking*.
3. Loudermilk, M., Sheu, G., & Taragin, C. (2023). *Beyond “Horizontal” and “Vertical”: The welfare effects of complex integration* (No. 2023-005; Finance and Economics Discussion Series). Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System. <https://doi.org/10.17016/FEDS.2023.005>

## PRESENTATIONS

|                                                  |                |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| FEDERAL TRADE COMMISSION                         | 11/2025        |
| DC IO DAY                                        | 5/2019         |
| INTERNATIONAL INDUSTRIAL ORGANIZATION CONFERENCE | 4/2019         |
| FEDERAL TRADE COMMISSION                         | 6/2018, 7/2018 |
| INTERNATIONAL COMPETITION NETWORK                | 2018           |
| INTERNATIONAL INDUSTRIAL ORGANIZATION CONFERENCE | 2018           |
| FEDERAL COMMUNICATION COMMISSION                 | 8/2018, 2013   |
| U.S. DEPARTMENT OF JUSTICE                       | 2012, 2017     |

## R SOFTWARE PACKAGES

### ANTITRUST

- A collection of tools for antitrust practitioners, including merger simulation models, market definition, and equilibrium pricing. Calibrates demand parameters and simulates mergers under various differentiated products demand systems including logit, nested logit, ces, and aids.

### TRADE

- A collection of tools for trade policy analysis. Provides trade policy practitioners with a tractable framework for simulating the effects of tariffs, quotas, and other trade policy measures on market outcomes.

### COMPETITIONTOOLBOX

- A graphical user interface for the antitrust and trade R packages. Provides an interactive interface for conducting merger simulations, market definition analysis, and trade policy analysis without requiring R programming knowledge.

## SERVICE

|                                        |      |
|----------------------------------------|------|
| US DOJ/KFTC KNOWLEDGE EXCHANGE PROGRAM | 2018 |
|----------------------------------------|------|

- Organized, co-authored and co-taught a 3 day training program for new economists at the Korean Free Trade Commission (KFTC). The purpose of this program was to train KFTC economists in how to analyze horizontal mergers.

|                             |      |
|-----------------------------|------|
| ALGORITHMIC DOCUMENT REVIEW | 2017 |
|-----------------------------|------|

- Trained a series of machine learning classifiers to predict if a document is pertinent to an investigation. Once these models have been fully tested, they will greatly reduce the time needed to review the massive amount of documents received by the Antitrust Division.

|            |                |
|------------|----------------|
| R TRAINING | 2012 - present |
|------------|----------------|

- Authored and co-taught a series of short courses for Economists and Research Analysts on R. Covered topics included: data analysis, plotting, regression analysis, mapping, interfacing with databases, and antitrust analysis.

## AWARDS

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|------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| TEAM SPECIAL ACHIEVEMENT AWARD FOR WORK ON CAPITAL ONE/DISCOVER MERGER | 2025 |
| EAG MANAGEMENT AWARD FOR POSITIVE EXTERNALITY                          | 2019 |
| TEAM AWARD FOR WORK ON ANTHEM/CIGNA LITIGATION                         | 2017 |
| EAG MANAGEMENT AWARD FOR EXTRAORDINARY ACHIEVEMENT                     | 2016 |
| TEAM AWARD FOR WORK ON NATIONAL CINEMEDIA/SCREENVISION LITIGATION      | 2015 |
| TEAM AWARD FOR WORK ON AMERICAN/US AIRWAYS LITIGATION                  | 2014 |
| EAG MANAGEMENT AWARD FOR PUSHING FRONTIERS                             | 2010 |

## COMPUTER SKILLS

#### AI & LLM TOOLS

- Claude Code, OpenAI Codex

#### PROGRAMMING

- Python, C++, Java

#### STATISTICS

- R, Stata, SAS

#### DATABASE

- PostgreSQL, PostGIS, MySQL, Microsoft SQL, DuckDB, SQLite

#### MARKUP

- Markdown, LaTeX